

DWAYNE & QIANA

Where are we waking up?

Thursday, October 1 → Sunday, October 4, 2026 · three nights

You said overwater bungalow. So I went and found every single one we can actually reach from Chicago in three nights, priced them out, and threw away the ones that don't work. Here they are. Pick one.

OPTION SET 1

We fly

Four that fit three nights, and four that look great until you check the flight.

RIVIERA MAYA · MEXICO

MY PICK

Palafitos

at El Dorado Maroma · adults only

Fly from Midway, nonstop

In the air 3h 40m

Airport to room 45 to 60 min drive

Door to door about 7 hours

All inclusive Yes, plus butler

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$4,300 to \$4,800

Thirty thatched bungalows on stilts over the water at Maroma Beach. Glass floor panel in the room, your own infinity pool on the deck, outdoor shower, ladder straight down into the sea. **These are the only true overwater bungalows in Mexico.** Leave Midway in the morning, be in the water by afternoon.

Easiest trip

Adults only

Seaweed possible

ARUBA

Aruba Ocean Villas

Savaneta · boutique, couples

Fly from O'Hare, nonstop

In the air about 5h

Airport to room 20 to 25 min drive

Door to door 7 to 8 hours

All inclusive No, meals extra

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$3,500 to \$4,200

Thatched villas over clear shallow water on the quiet south end, far from the high rise strip. Hardwood decks, ladders into the sea. **Aruba sits outside the hurricane belt**, so early October there is just a normal beach week instead of a gamble. Cheapest of the good ones.

Best weather odds

Lowest price

O'Hare only

BELIZE

Thatch Caye

a Muy'Ono Resort · private island

Fly from O'Hare, likely 1 stop

Then Puddle jumper + speedboat

Door to door about 12 hours

Usable time roughly 1.5 of 3 days

All inclusive Yes, transfers too

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$3,600 to \$6,200

Fifteen overwater bungalows on a private island inside the barrier reef. Genuinely beautiful, and the one we originally saw. **But October is Belize's wettest month, about ten inches of rain, at the peak of hurricane season,** and reef boat trips get cancelled. This is a February trip, not an October one.

Worst month

Two travel days

BOCAS DEL TORO · PANAMA

Azul Paradise

overwater bungalows on the lagoon

Fly from O'Hare + 2nd flight

Then Boat to the island

Door to door about 14 hours

Usable time roughly 1.5 of 3 days

All inclusive Yes, on the package

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$2,750 to \$3,200

Ten bungalows on stilts over a turquoise lagoon, glass floor panel, private sundeck, hammock hanging over the water. **By far the cheapest real overwater bungalow on this list.** The catch is two of our three days go to airports, and the vibe is rustic barefoot rather than luxury.

Cheapest overall

Rustic

Two travel days

BELIZE · PREMIUM

Cayo Espanto

Casa Ventanas · private island, 7 villas

Door to door about 12 hours

All inclusive Yes, private butler

Included 3 meals, drinks, sailboat

Extra charges 9% tax + 15% island fee

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$11,500 to \$14,000

A bungalow floating at the end of a 150 foot dock with its own butler and sailboat. Honestly **the best property on this entire page.** It is also the worst possible month to go, so my advice is to keep this one in our back pocket for February or March and give it five or six nights instead of three.

Most special

Wrong month

ST. LUCIA

Sandals Grande St. Lucian

over the water butler bungalows

Fly from No October nonstop

Door to door 9 to 10 hours

All inclusive Yes, plus 3 resorts

Adults only Yes

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$7,100 to \$7,900

Beautiful bungalows and you get run of three Sandals resorts on the island. **The problem is purely arithmetic:** with a connection each way, two of our three days become travel days. Worth it for a week. Not worth it for three nights.

Full butler

Bad flight math

ST. VINCENT

Sandals Saint Vincent

two story overwater villas

Fly from No nonstop, usually 2 stops

Door to door 12 to 14 hours

All inclusive Yes

Adults only Yes

ESTIMATED TOTAL, ALL IN

\$11,500 to \$13,500

The newest and arguably the nicest overwater villas Sandals has built, two full stories out over the water. **Also the hardest to get to on the whole list.** Two connections each way means we would spend more time in airports than in the villa.

Newest villas

Two full travel days

JAMAICA

Sandals Jamaica

Royal Caribbean & South Coast

Fly from Midway route is Nov to Apr

Status Closed / renovating

Reopens December 18, 2026

AVAILABILITY

Not an option

Including it so you know I checked. **Royal Caribbean is closed until December 18, 2026** and reopening under a new name, South Coast is mid way through a \$200M rebuild after Hurricane Melissa, and the Midway to Montego Bay flight is a winter only route that does not run in October. Three strikes.

Unavailable

SIDE BY SIDE

The numbers, if you want them

Swipe sideways on your phone. Gold column is my pick.

	RIVIERA MAYA	ARUBA	BELIZE	PANAMA	ST. LUCIA
Property	Palafitos	Aruba Ocean Villas	Thatch Caye	Azul Paradise	Sandals Grande
Fly out of	Midway, nonstop	O'Hare, nonstop	O'Hare, 1 stop	O'Hare, 2 flights	O'Hare, 2 flights
Time in the air	3h 40m	about 5h	4h 22m to 7h	6h 30m plus boat	7h plus connect
Door to door	about 7 hours	7 to 8 hours	about 12 hours	about 14 hours	9 to 10 hours
Usable time	nearly all 3 days	nearly all 3 days	about 1.5 days	about 1.5 days	about 1.5 days
Per night	\$1,100 to \$1,250	\$549 to \$1,579	\$600 to \$1,200	\$375 to \$450	\$1,900 to \$2,022
All inclusive	Yes, plus butler	No	Yes	Yes, on package	Yes, plus butler
Flights for two	about \$800	\$1,000 to \$1,400	\$1,200 to \$1,600	\$1,400 to \$1,800	\$1,400 to \$1,800
Total, 3 nights	\$4,300 to \$4,800	\$3,500 to \$4,200	\$3,600 to \$6,200	\$2,750 to \$3,200	\$7,100 to \$7,900
Early Oct weather	Rain fading	Dry, 82 to 88°F	Wettest month	Wet season	Rainy season
Hurricane risk	Moderate, falling	Essentially none	Peak	Outside the belt	Moderate
Adults only	Yes	Couples focused	No	No	Yes
The catch	Seaweed is possible	Meals not included	Wrong month entirely	Two travel days	Two travel days

We cruise

Same treatment, same honesty, still being researched.

Cruise options are still being pulled

I have eight researchers working through the October 2026 sailing calendars, the Chicago flights to each port, hurricane rerouting policies, and the true all in cost per couple. Including whether we can book an overwater cabana on a private island as a day. This section fills in shortly.

So, pick one

You do not have to weigh all of that. Here is the short version, in the order I would choose.

1. **Riviera Maya.** If the experience is the point. Only one where we leave Midway in the morning and are in the water that afternoon.
2. **Aruba.** If you want zero weather anxiety. Outside the hurricane belt, cheapest of the good ones, we just pay for our own dinners.
3. **Panama.** If price is the point and you do not mind roughing the travel.
4. **Cayo Espanto.** Not now. Let's save this one and do it right in February.

Say a name and I will book it.

Prices are published ranges and October averages, not live quotes for our exact dates, so the final number will move a little. Both passports are current, so nothing is blocking us. Palafitos has only thirty bungalows and we are about three and a half weeks out, so whichever way you lean, sooner is better.

Put together September 6, 2026.